



DESIGN NOTE

Officer and Soldier Leadership Development

AITC DISCUSSION PIECE, TWO PAGES PLUS A DETACHABLE FUTURE STATE: DESIGN DRAFT

New Zealand Army Leadership Centre | Army Command School

Reference: NZDF Leadership Framework v2 (Oct 2025); LDS, Leadership Levels and Leadership Framework posters · **Date:** September 2026 · **Status:** Design draft for approval

1. The Tasking, Reduced to Its Point

COMDT ACS asked ACS (ALC) to table a discussion piece at the AITC before end of year on how the Officer and Other Rank promotion continuums align with the intent and design of the LDF: present the facts and challenge the organisation to decide about the development of leaders at all levels. The trigger was a request to link Lead Leaders to promotion to substantive Captain.

Read against that, the issue is narrow:

Army applies a deliberate link between leadership development and promotion within the Soldier continuum. The equivalent relationship within the Officer continuum is less clear. Is this difference deliberate, and if so, why?

The earlier seven-page construct tested six categories at six transitions for two continuums. That was a diagnostic of the whole system. COMDT is asking a sharper question, so the product is reduced to two pages and the six-category matrix is withdrawn from the briefing product.

On 9 September 2026 Mike and Dave walked each transition of both continuums and recorded what is mandated, what is recommended, what is policed in function, and what history the decision-makers should have. That meeting is now the main source for the cells on page 1. Everything it stated is tagged STATED 9 SEP until it is checked against promotion policy and the promotion-course data sheets. The meeting also actioned a current-versus-desired mapping, which is carried as a detachable third page.

2. The Pages

Page	Purpose	What is on it
1. Two continuums. One leadership framework.	Show the asymmetry	One visual. The LDF's seven levels as the spine. Officer continuum on the left, Soldier continuum on the right, each showing rank, the development intervention at that point, and whether it is mandated. Headline question above; the question for Army beneath.

2. The discrepancy	Let the answer emerge, give the background, then pose the challenge	Two flows with identical steps. Soldier: promotion point, development mandated in policy, development completed, promotion: a deliberate link. Officer: promotion point, development exists and is recommended, not in policy (policed in function at T2, self-selected from T3), promotion: an unclear link. A background strip: what has been tried, why it stalled, and the explanation offered at the meeting, marked as not established. Then: is this difference a conscious choice? If so, what is the rationale? If not, should Army apply a more consistent principle?
3. Current and desired: one page (detachable)	Answer the meeting action for a current-versus-desired mapping	One table: LDF transition, then for each continuum the rank, the course and who delivers it, the mandate now, and the desired mandate. Shaded cells are the change. Below it: what changes (a mandate written into promotion policy, ILD seats aligned to Army promotion timing, the officer window placed after unit experience) and what does not (no new courses, no new money). Tabled only if the room answers page 2 with "not a conscious choice".

The three wordings are fixed:

Place	Wording
Headline, page 1	How deliberately does Army link leadership development to progression through its Officer and Soldier promotion continuums?
Question, foot of page 1	If Army deliberately mandates leadership development for soldiers as they progress through increased leadership responsibility, why is the same principle not applied consistently to officers?
Challenge, page 2	Is this difference a conscious choice? If so, what is the rationale for treating Officer and Soldier leadership development differently? If not, should Army apply a more consistent principle to development before progression into increased leadership responsibility?

3. Why the LDF Stays in the Middle

The LDF is retained as the spine because it is the common reference that makes the comparison fair. Its levels describe progressively different leadership requirements: a genuine shift from effective individual contribution, to getting things done through others, through other leaders, to running a system, building capability, integrating at enterprise level, and stewarding the institution. Placing the two continuums against it allows one question to be asked at each transition: at the same developmental shift, what does Army require of a soldier, and what does it require of an officer?

Two points from the sources still govern how the spine is used.

- 1. The rank mapping is an estimate.** The Leadership Levels poster says its alignment of rank to level is "only an estimation". Rank pairings on page 1 place the comparison; they do not assert that a rank equals a level. The page says so in one line.

2. **The LDS intends development before the transition.** The Leadership Development System places the LDS course in the Orientation phase, ideally about six months before the first posting to the new level. Whether Army's promotion courses achieve that for either continuum is part of what the facts must show.

4. What Is Known and What Is Not

Populated cells on page 1 now rest on the 9 September meeting, read against the four source documents and the NZALC course data sheets. Ranks follow the meeting: WO2 is the Lead Systems tick and WO1 the Lead Capability tick.

Transition	Soldier	Officer
Entry	Lead Self compulsory on entry, delivered through train-the-trainer (TAD, ACS)	Lead Self compulsory, as for soldiers
T1 Lead Self to Lead Teams	PTE to LCPL. Mandated: ELDA Lead Teams (A18011) is embedded in the JNCO course (A1530) as the performance-under-pressure module, with LDS Lead Teams (D03020) sequenced alongside	OCDT to 2LT. Embedded: NZCC includes ELDA Lead Teams (the former Nemesis, rebranded with the same learning outcomes) and LDS Lead Teams, delivered by ALC at OCS in March, two years running
T2 Lead Teams to Lead Leaders	CPL to SGT. Mandated in promotion policy: the SNCO course (A1531) carries ELDA Lead Leaders (A18008) and LDS Lead Leaders (D03030). "Very clear on the NCO front"	2LT and LT to CAPT. Recommended, not mandated: not in promotion policy, but policed in function by OCS and COs so that in practice no 2LT or LT promotes without it. "Super murky on the officer front". This is the substantive CAPT request
T3 Lead Leaders to Lead Systems	SSGT to WO2. ELDA Lead Systems (A18010) mandated on the WO course (A1532). LDS Lead Systems is ILD-delivered and Army cannot guarantee seats, so it is routinely done before or after the promotion course. Whether it is a prerequisite for WO2 is Dave's action	CAPT to MAJ. Neither ELDA Lead Systems nor the ILD LDS Lead Systems course is mandated, and neither is policed in function. Uptake is self-selecting. CAPT to OC is the largest single jump in scope of influence
T4 Lead Systems to Lead Capability	WO2 to WO1. LDS Lead Capability (ILD). Expected for promotion; "pretty sure" not in policy. Most attend, subject to an ILD seat	MAJ to LTCOL. LDS Lead Capability (ILD). Not mandated; the impression is that all complete it
T5 Lead Capability to Lead Integrated Capability	WO1s. One ELDA week (ALC caving or Navy sailing) and one LDS week in Wellington, both run and funded by ILD. 12 to 16 students a course; attended without exception	LTCOL and COL. The same course; attended without exception
T6 Lead Integrated Capability to Lead Organisation	Senior WO1s considered for the senior appointments. LDS Lead Organisation with an ELDA component (retreat setting, equine behaviour, psychometric profiling, external facilitation); all complete it well before they need to	COL and BRIG. The same course; all complete it well before required

Two structural facts from the meeting shape the reading of the table.

1. **The 2012 division of delivery.** Single-Service providers train Lead Self to Lead Leaders, which covers most of the organisation. ILD trains Lead Systems and above for all three Services, and Army retains the ELDA function at those levels. Army therefore cannot guarantee an ILD seat,

which is why LDS Lead Systems sits outside the WO promotion course and why a mandate above T2 is harder to enforce on either continuum.

2. **Where the gap bites.** Attendance is near-universal at LTCOL and above and at WO1 and above, because those groups are selected, scrutinised and ambitious. The formative years in unit, 2LT to MAJ, are where leadership development is missed, and where the promotion policy carries no marker.

The background the decision-makers should have, carried on page 2, is also from the meeting: a two-year pilot attaching Lead Leaders to Grade 2 and 3 coursing was withdrawn as untenable time away from units; a distributed, self-scheduled approach was agreed instead; the Post Commissioning Programme delivered Lead Leaders to every junior officer but before unit experience; AITC agreed in principle that officers should complete it and the proposal was parked in a headquarters restructure; and ACS was not at the table for later course redesigns.

Dave's own answer to COMDT's question, offered at the meeting and shown on page 2 as a candidate rather than a finding, was "a scheduling oversight in the face of tempo": training that is not required is the training that gets bumped.

The facts still required are the same three for every transition on each side, and are listed in the accompanying register:

1. **Promotion point.** The authoritative Army promotion or career point that corresponds to the transition.
2. **Development intervention.** The course or programme that develops the individual for that transition, with its SOLO code.
3. **Mandate.** Whether that development is a prerequisite for promotion, embedded in the promotion course, expected but not mandatory, or unconnected. For the officer side at T2 to T4 this is now a check of promotion policy against what the meeting stated, not an open question.

5. Tone

The piece does not set out to prove the Officer system wrong. COMDT's posture is the intellectual stance: are we consciously choosing to deviate from best practice, and if so, why? There may be a defensible reason for treating Officer development differently. The job of the two pages is to expose the difference clearly enough that Army has to articulate that reason, or decide to change. Both branches of the closing question are given equal weight, and no recommendation is attached.

6. What Has Been Withdrawn

The six-category matrix (rank, appointment, development, career linkage, timing, assurance), the gap taxonomy, and the seven-page sequence remain in the repository history as analytical scaffolding. They are not part of the briefing product. If AITC asks for the fuller diagnostic after the discussion, they can be revived from the retained data register without redesign.

7. Actions From the 9 September Meeting

Action	Owner	Where it lands in this product
Verify whether the ILD LDS Lead Systems course is a prerequisite in the promotion-course data sheet for SSGT to WO2	Dave	Page 1, soldier T3; register row T3-R-MAND

Check officer promotion requirements in policy for leadership training mandates at each rank	Team	Page 1, officer T2 to T6; register rows T2-O-MAND to T6-O-MAND, and X1
Develop a visual mapping of the current versus desired framework, highlighting discrepancies and critical points	Team	Pages 1 and 3
Confirm timing and scheduling of the courses at each transition and their delivery mechanism	Team	Page 3, course and delivery columns; register X3 and X6
Prepare a future-state plan: progression levels, delivery agents, policy endorsements linking training to promotion	Team	Page 3, held as detachable until AITC answers page 2